Live Coding: New perspectives on generative art

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Artist Talk

Live Coding is a relatively youthful performance practice that explores the definition and manipulation of process in a real-time improvisatory setting. To date, computer programming languages provide the most powerful formal languages which humanity has yet devised for the description and manipulation of process. It is these computer programming languages that Live Coding practitioners use to create and perform musical/visual works in a live performance setting. Typically practitioners build and manipulate generative structures during a performance, leaving these structures to "perform" while the performer creates new structures, either to replace or "perform" in counterpoint with existing material. Generative structures often start simply and are subsequently expanded and modified by the live programmer as the performance unfolds. Live programming usually involves the projection of the code enabling the audience to engage with the construction of the works internal processes.

For the past two years I have focused on Live Coding performance practice, working on the tools and ideas that allow me to explore code as a medium for real-time audio/visual expression. My current live coding practice is centred around base notions of periodicity, linearity, probability and recursion. These processes will be well known to many of you and have been fundamental to generative music making for many decades. The real-time constraints imposed by Live Coding has encouraged me to reengage with these base functions, providing an intimacy of process and a connection with medium, often lost through higher level abstraction.

This talk will discuss some of these ideas and provide practical demonstrations of some aspects of the discussion.